PRODUCT TEARDOWN SERIES

Notion Agents: doing more for less

Pricing, routing and cost control for long-running AI agents

Source post: *Agents, rebuilt to do more for less*, Akshay Kothari, 19 Oct 2026
Teardown date: 9 Nov 2026 (revised after primary-source check) | Author: Kris

How to read this teardown

A teardown is only useful if you can tell what the company said from what the analyst concluded. Every block in this document carries one of these labels.

DISCLOSED	Stated by Notion in the source post (or its own help pages, where named).
EXTERNAL SOURCE	Reported by another company or a third-party site. Dated and attributed in the text.
INTERPRETATION	My reading of the evidence. Reasonable, but not confirmed by Notion.
PROPOSAL	A product or project idea of mine. Not something Notion announced.
UNKNOWN	A number or fact nobody outside Notion can know yet (retention, CAC, margin, and so on).

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Executive summary

Thesis. INTERPRETATION The October announcement is less a feature launch than an attempt to make autonomous work *financeable*: a router to cut the cost of each task, a rebuilt harness to cut waste inside each task, and a credit system to make the remaining spend legible and governable. The product bet is that agents can run for hours only if the bill stays predictable.

Five takeaways

1. **Efficiency is the precondition for autonomy.** DISCLOSED Notion's head of AI said long-running threads had to be paired with efficiency gains so they would not burn through credits. Tasks went from five minutes to more than 24 hours; Custom Agent runs cost about 30% less in testing.
2. **Routing moves the model choice from the user to the vendor.** DISCLOSED The post says Auto matched frontier-model results at about 90% lower cost; Notion's help page puts the average at 87% lower than Opus 5.5 and describes the method (thousands of replayed tasks, head-to-head judging). UNKNOWN The underlying data and task mix are not public, so treat the figure as vendor-reported.
3. **Two credit pools contain risk.** DISCLOSED Standard credits (1,500 per seat per month) cover Auto work; Select credits (500) cover model choice and Custom Agents. INTERPRETATION This protects everyday use from a few expensive agents, at the price of a harder mental model.
4. **Run-level cost control is the open flank.** DISCLOSED Per-agent spending caps, per-member credit limits, alerts at 80% and 100%, and automatic pausing are already documented in Notion's help pages. INTERPRETATION What is missing is a budget per *run* and a cost estimate before the run starts, which matter most for 24-hour agents.
5. **There is room for a cross-vendor layer.** INTERPRETATION Every vendor is shipping its own credits and its own dashboard. An agent cost and usage platform that normalises them is a credible project for a PM portfolio (Section 10).

Short answer to the pricing question. PROPOSAL Charge a *seat* for access and governance, meter *credits* for compute, price *outcomes* for customer-facing agents, and put a *budget envelope* around anything that runs unattended. No single unit (seat, task, execution or credit) survives contact with a 24-hour agent on its own.

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1 Context

What market and product problem are we studying?

Market. AI inside work tools has moved from a chat box to autonomous work: agents that call hundreds of tools, run for many hours and act on a team's behalf. The unit of value changed from "a response" to "a finished task", and the unit of cost changed with it.

Product problem. How do you let an agent work for a long time, on a model the user did not have to choose, without producing a surprise invoice? That is a pricing problem, an architecture problem and a governance problem at once. The Notion post addresses all three in one announcement, which is why it makes a good teardown.

DISCLOSED BY NOTION

- Notion added seven new models in the past month from Anthropic, OpenAI and open-weight providers.
- Agents can work on a single task for more than 24 hours, up from five minutes.
- Agents connect to hundreds of tools through MCP and connectors, up from a few dozen earlier in the summer.
- Notion says people often default to high-cost models for most requests.
- Existing customers moved to the new credit system on 2 November 2026 (new customers from 19 October).

INTERPRETATION

The post reads like a feature release but is mainly a unit-economics announcement. Model prices, model count and task length all moved at once, so Notion needed a layer that absorbs that volatility on the customer's behalf. The router is that layer for cost; the credit system is that layer for billing. Note also that the migration date has already passed as of this writing, so early customer reaction exists but is not public.

Scope of this teardown. We study Notion's agent efficiency and credit design, not Notion as a whole. Where the post is silent, I mark the gap rather than fill it.

2 Target user

Who experiences this problem?

Four distinct people feel the problem differently. Treating them as one "user" is the most common mistake in AI pricing teardowns.

Persona	Job to be done	Core pain	Notion's answer
Knowledge worker (everyday user)	Write, summarise, ask questions inside the workspace	Picking a model; fear of running out of credits	Auto router, Standard credits; own usage view
Custom Agent builder (team lead, ops)	Automate a recurring workflow	Unknown cost per run; paying before proving value	Select credits to try agents free of extra purchase; per-agent spend view
Workspace admin / IT	Know what runs, who owns it and what it costs	Usage scattered across several screens	Member usage dashboard, credit limits and per-agent caps (live per help pages); AI Command Center (announced)
Power user with own AI stack	Use ChatGPT or other agents against Notion data	Paying for AI twice	ChatGPT plan connection, BYOK (alpha), improved MCP

DISCLOSED BY NOTION

Notion states that admins need to know what is running, who owns it and what it costs, that this information previously lived in multiple places, and that members will be able to see how many included credits they have used and what each of their own agents spends. It also says customers increasingly use Notion as infrastructure for their own agents.

INTERPRETATION

The economic buyer (admin, IT, finance) and the daily user are different people with opposed incentives: users want freedom to choose the best model, buyers want a ceiling. A good credit system has to serve both, which explains the separation of Standard (safe default) from Select (elective, metered).

3 Problem discovery

What existing workflow is painful?

Reading the post for the workflows it is trying to replace gives five pain points. The first four are directly implied by what Notion says it fixed; the fifth is my addition.

Painful workflow	What happens today	Evidence level
Choosing a model per task	Users default to expensive models "to be safe"; releases arrive almost weekly	DISCLOSED (Notion's claim)
Long tasks that fail or burn credits	Sessions die on restarts; agents reread bloated context on every step	DISCLOSED (Notion lists durable execution and compaction as fixes)
Paying for AI twice	A team already holds ChatGPT plans or model keys	DISCLOSED (BYOK called a top recent request)
Opaque spend	No single place to see usage by member, feature and agent	DISCLOSED (Notion apologises for the earlier scatter)
Surprise exhaustion of a shared pool	A few heavy agents consume the allowance everyone shares	INTERPRETATION (inferred from the reason given for two pools)

NOT DISCLOSED / UNKNOWN

How Notion discovered these problems is not disclosed: no interview counts, support-ticket volumes, churn reasons or usage distributions are shared. The post says many improvements began as customer feedback, which is a source, not evidence. Also unknown: the share of workspaces that actually exhausted credits under the previous system.

4 Product thesis

Why did the company choose this solution?

What Notion says its role is. DISCLOSED "Our job" is to offer a model-agnostic context layer that works with any model from any provider, while making AI cheaper to run, keeping model choice open and being candid about changes.

Three bets I read inside that thesis.

1. INTERPRETATION **A router beats user choice.** If users cannot judge quality per dollar across a fast-moving model list, the vendor should do it and re-evaluate weekly.

2. INTERPRETATION **Efficiency must precede autonomy.** Long runs are only sellable if cost per step falls first. The order of work in the post (router, harness, then credits) matches that logic.
3. INTERPRETATION **Separate the predictable from the elastic.** Two pools keep ordinary use safe while agent experimentation draws from its own allowance.

INTERPRETATION

Alternatives Notion could have chosen: a single frontier model for everything (simple, but expensive and fragile to one provider), flat unlimited seats (predictable for buyers, dangerous for margin), or pure pay-per-run (fair, but frightening for buyers). The chosen design is a hybrid that favours buyer predictability first and vendor margin second. Making the workspace the context layer also positions Notion as neutral ground even when users bring ChatGPT, Claude or another agent, which turns possible substitutes into traffic.

5 Product experience

How does the user move from input to outcome?

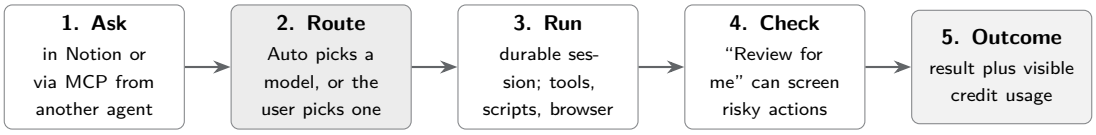


Figure 1. The user journey, assembled from disclosed capabilities. The sequence itself is my reconstruction.

Four journeys, four credit paths

Journey	What the user does	Credits used
Everyday question in Notion Agent	Writes, summarises, asks; leaves model on Auto	Standard (1,500 per seat per month)
Pick a specific model	Chooses a model in the picker for harder work	Select (500 per seat per month)
Custom Agent on a schedule	Builds an agent that runs unattended, perhaps for hours	Select first; then credits assigned by an owner; then workspace Notion credits if allowed
Own ChatGPT plan	Connects ChatGPT Plus, Pro or Go to personal Notion Agent	Not Notion credits

DISCLOSED BY NOTION

The ChatGPT connection works in personal Notion Agent first, not in Custom Agents. Auto is on by default in the model picker, in Notion Agent chat and in Custom Agent settings, and users can pin a model instead (Auto help page). Select credits reset monthly and do not roll over. A Custom Agent draws first on its owner's Select credits, then on any extra Notion credit allowance, then on workspace Notion credits if an owner allows it. Owners can set a spending cap per agent. If Select credits run out and no Notion credits are available, the agent pauses until credits reset or are funded (help pages). Custom Agents created before 2 November 2026 keep drawing on shared workspace credits.

INTERPRETATION

The experience is clean for the first journey and increasingly demanding for the others: the user must know which pool pays, and a Custom Agent builder must reason about three funding layers. Notion's help page also says usage is visible per run after the fact, so the experience today is closer to "see what it

> cost" than "decide what it may cost".

6 AI architecture

What role do models, tools, context and memory play?

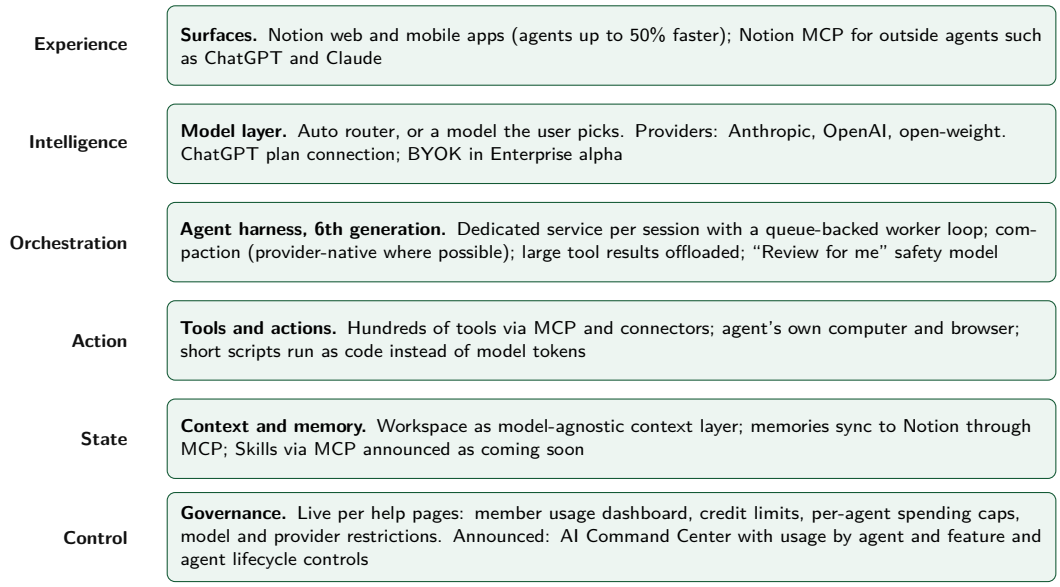


Figure 2. Agent stack as disclosed in the post. Green = described as live in the post or Notion help pages. Layer names on the left are mine.

Layer	Disclosed (DISCLOSED)	Gap or reading (INTERPRETATION / UNKNOWN)
Models	Auto is a router, not a Notion-built model. It reads each task and picks from models the workspace allows, using Notion's evaluations of quality, speed, cost and reliability. It can move to a more capable model for a demanding step and back again, re-routes when a model makes no meaningful progress, and falls back to the next lowest-cost allowed model if an owner restricts options. Users cannot see which models Auto used (Auto help page)	UNKNOWN The signals the router uses, misroute rate, router latency overhead
Tools	MCP and connectors; computer and browser use; agent writes short scripts instead of spending tokens	INTERPRETATION Code-as-tool is the main structural cost lever alongside routing: deterministic work leaves the token meter
Context	Compaction using each provider's native method where possible; large tool outputs offloaded, not pasted into the window	INTERPRETATION Cost per step falls because the context reread each step shrinks; quality effects of compaction are not reported
Memory	Memories can sync to Notion via MCP; Notion positions itself as shared brain for agents	UNKNOWN How memory is scoped, permissioned and expired
Safety	"Review for me" mode uses a separate model to check whether an action is safe before it runs	UNKNOWN False-positive rate, added latency, extra credit cost of the reviewer
Reliability	Queue-backed worker loop; infrastructure uptime above 99.9%	UNKNOWN Share of 24-hour runs that complete; recovery behaviour after failure

7 Trade-offs

Quality vs cost, speed vs reasoning, autonomy vs control

7.1 The router, drawn

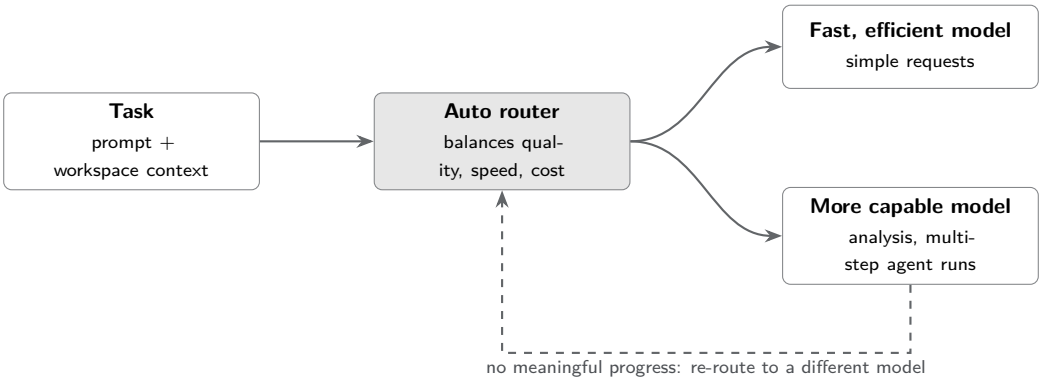


Figure 3. Behaviour described in the post, redrawn by me. Routing signals and thresholds are not disclosed.

7.2 The headline number, in proportion

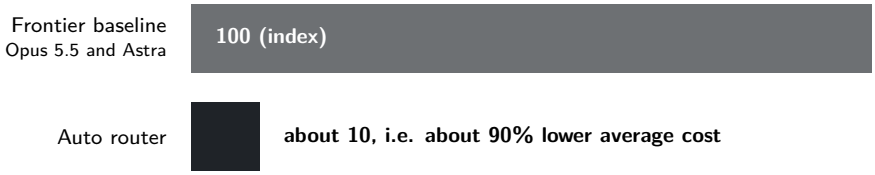


Figure 4. Relative average cost per task across 20+ common use cases, as reported by Notion (similar quality claimed). Index is mine; Notion published a chart without raw values in the text.

Axis	Which way Notion leans	What it costs the user
Quality vs cost	Auto trades peak quality for large savings and claims parity on common work (DISCLOSED)	INTERPRETATION Hard tasks may be underserved on the first attempt; the re-route fallback reduces but does not remove this
Speed vs reasoning	Fast models for simple work; capable models for analysis and multi-step runs (DISCLOSED). Apps up to 50% faster (DISCLOSED)	INTERPRETATION Users cannot tell whether a slow answer is deep thought or a misroute
Autonomy vs control	24-hour runs, plus "Review for me" and admin controls (DISCLOSED)	INTERPRETATION Pausing at credit exhaustion protects the budget but can strand half-finished work
Simplicity vs transparency	Two named pools instead of per-model rates (DISCLOSED)	INTERPRETATION Fewer numbers to learn, but "which pool pays?" becomes the new support question
Notion's margin vs customer cost	Notion says most users are unlikely to run out of credits (DISCLOSED, an estimate)	UNKNOWN Margin per credit, share of workspaces buying extra credits

NOT DISCLOSED / UNKNOWN

Notion's help page puts the average saving at 87% against Opus 5.5 (the post says about 90%) and describes the method: thousands of common tasks replayed in a simulated Notion environment, outputs compared head to head, an Elo score per model, then an AI judge trained to match those rankings. Still unpublished: the task mix, the judge's agreement with humans on this test, the baseline cost for a typical user rather than a frontier-only user, and whether retries and re-routes are inside the saving. Treat it as a

vendor-reported result.

7.3 What the credit allowance is worth

DISCLOSED BY NOTION

Notion's Auto help page estimates credits per task: Auto 5, 10 and 25 for simple, medium and complex work; Opus 5.5 50, 85 and 150. Business and Enterprise seats include 500 Select credits per month (post). Credits are listed at $10 per 1,000 (buy-and-track help page).

INTERPRETATION

My arithmetic from those figures: 500 Select credits cover about 100, 50 or 20 runs on Auto, but only about 10, 5 or 3 runs if the user pins Opus 5.5. At the list rate (an assumption: Notion does not say Select credits are priced like purchased ones) 500 credits is about $5 per seat per month, and 1,500 Standard credits about $15. The ten-fold gap between Auto and a pinned frontier model is the practical reason Select is a separate pool: one manual model choice can cost ten times as much. The cost of a 24-hour run is not disclosed.

7.4 What Notion's own evaluation pages add

DISCLOSED BY NOTION

The Notion Knowledge Board (last updated 16 October 2026) compares models on real, anonymised agent requests. About 7% of weekly agent traffic is split evenly across models, each at high reasoning effort. An ensemble of three AI judges scores each transcript as resolved or not, with a 2-of-3 majority deciding. Notion reports resolution rate, cost per task, resolution time and undo rate, with confidence intervals. Judge agreement with 100 expert-labelled transcripts was 92.9% (kappa 0.595), and Notion notes the judge may be slightly lenient. Headline results: Opus 5.5 and GPT-6.1-Sol are statistically tied at about 98.8% resolution, at roughly $0.63 and $0.27 per task; DeepSeek V4.1 Flash reaches about 97.3% at $0.06 per task.

INTERPRETATION

Three readings. First, on Notion's task mix the quality gap between a frontier-priced model and a much cheaper one is small, which is the economic premise behind routing. Second, the judges are themselves AI models, some from providers whose models are being scored, so the numbers are directional rather than final; Notion's own note on leniency supports that caution. Third, the board scores individual models, and I did not see Auto itself listed, so it does not directly test the router.

8 Competition

What alternatives exist?

Competitors are not like-for-like. Each prices a different job, so the useful question is not "who is cheapest" but "what unit does each one bet customers will accept".

Player	Pricing unit	Reported meter and guardrails	Lesson for Notion
Notion DISCLOSED	Seat-bundled credits	1,500 Standard + 500 Select per seat per month (Business, Enterprise); credits $10 per 1,000; per-agent spending caps and per-member credit limits; owner alerts at 80% and 100%; agents pause at exhaustion and resume on reset or workspace credits	Strong containment at agent level; no per-run budget disclosed
Microsoft Copilot Studio EXTERNAL SOURCE	Credits per feature	Classic answer 1 credit, generative answer 2, agent action 5, tenant graph grounding 10 (Microsoft Learn). About $0.008 per credit in $200 packs of 25,000 and $0.01 pay-as-you-go (CloudZero, third party). At 125% of capacity agents are blocked, including conversations in progress, unless pay-as-you-go is on (Microsoft Learn)	Rate card by action makes cost estimable; a hard block mid-conversation is the failure to avoid
Salesforce Agentforce EXTERNAL SOURCE	Credits, conversations or per-user licences	Flex Credits $500 per 100,000 ($0.005 each); a standard action is 20 credits ($0.10). Conversations $2 each. User licences from $5 per month (needs Flex Credits) to $125 for add-ons with unmetered employee use. Flex Credits and conversations cannot be mixed in one org (Salesforce pricing page, modified 19 Oct 2026)	Offering several units admits no single unit fits every buyer
Fin (formerly Intercom) EXTERNAL SOURCE	Per resolved outcome	$0.99 per outcome inside a $49 monthly base that includes 50 resolutions. A resolution is confirmed or assumed (24 hours of silence). Not billed: escalations, failed procedures, abandoned chats; reopened resolutions are deducted (Fin help centre). Salesforce completed its acquisition on 10 Sep 2026; the release does not mention pricing	Outcome pricing aligns spend with value but needs a clean definition of "resolved"
Cursor EXTERNAL SOURCE	Seat tier plus weekly usage pool	$30, $100 and $200 tiers with a weekly pooled allowance; third-party models at API list price; monthly cap on paid overage; router modes on Teams and Enterprise (Cursor docs)	Weekly pools stop one heavy day draining a month
Bring your own agent DISCLOSED	Your existing AI plan	ChatGPT plans in personal Notion Agent; MCP lets outside agents use Notion as shared context	Both partner and substitute for Notion's own agent

EXTERNAL SOURCES

Figures come from vendor pages read on 9 November 2026: Microsoft Learn, the Salesforce pricing page and press releases, the Fin help centre and Cursor docs. The Copilot Studio capacity-pack price and pay-as-you-go rate are not on the Microsoft Learn page; they come from a third-party site (CloudZero) and should be checked against Microsoft's licensing guide. Vendor prices change often, so re-check before quoting.

INTERPRETATION

Notion's real differentiator is not the router (Cursor already offers routing modes) but the combination of a work graph that agents can read, a model-agnostic stance and a pooled credit system inside one seat. Its weakness against specialists is that it sells a horizontal workspace, so it cannot price by a clean outcome the way Fin does for support. Fin's "assumed resolution" rule shows the risk of outcome pricing: the vendor decides what counts as success.

9 Product gaps

What remains unresolved?

1. **No per-run budget or pre-run estimate.** DISCLOSED Owners can set a spending cap per agent and a credit limit per member, and usage is visible per run afterwards. INTERPRETATION Nothing documented lets an owner set a budget for a single run or see a likely cost before it starts, which matters most for multi-hour agents.
2. **Per-agent visibility is thin today.** DISCLOSED The post says the AI Command Center will show usage by member, feature and agent; the manage-credits help page describes a member-level dashboard that requires a credit limit to be set, and does not describe a per-agent breakdown. UNKNOWN When the Command Center ships and what it contains.
3. **Pause semantics are agent-level, not run-level.** DISCLOSED If an owner's Select credits run out and no Notion credits exist, the agent pauses until credits reset or are funded; Select credits reset monthly. INTERPRETATION A pause could therefore last until the next reset. UNKNOWN Whether a paused run keeps a resumable checkpoint and partial result.
4. **No outcome signal for customers.** DISCLOSED Notion measures resolution rate and undo rate when it compares models (Knowledge Board). INTERPRETATION I found no per-agent success or undo metric in the customer-facing credit pages, so a retry loop and a clean success look the same on the bill.
5. **The router is opaque.** DISCLOSED Users cannot see which models Auto used or how often, and one chat may involve several models. INTERPRETATION That limits trust and makes it hard to explain an unexpectedly high bill.
6. **Two pools, one mental model.** INTERPRETATION "Which credits pay for this?" needs a lookup: Auto in Notion Agent uses Standard, a pinned model uses Select, and Custom Agents use the owner's Select credits even on Auto.
7. **Cross-agent attribution.** DISCLOSED Outside agents can reach Notion through MCP, and running an agent through a connected app or the API uses Notion credits. INTERPRETATION The outside model's cost sits on another bill, so nobody sees the full cost of one task.

10 Your proposal

What would you improve and why?

10.1 Pricing: my answers to the four questions

How should AI agents be priced? Seat, task, execution or credit?

Unit	What it prices	Strength	Weakness
Seat	Access of a person	Predictable for buyers; simple sales	Decouples price from heavy agent usage; margin risk
Task	A request the user sees	Easy to understand	Tasks vary by orders of magnitude in cost
Execution (run, step, action)	Work done by the agent	Tracks cost closely; Agentforce uses $0.10 per action (EXTERNAL SOURCE)	Hard to forecast; users fear every click
Credit	An abstracted bundle of compute	Hides model churn; one currency across features	Opaque unless a rate card is published
Outcome	A result the customer values	Best alignment with value (Fin: $0.99 per resolution, EXTERNAL SOURCE)	Needs a crisp, auditable definition of success

PROPOSAL

My recommendation: a hybrid with a clear job for each layer.

1. **Seat** for access, governance and a modest included allowance. Buyers need a number they can budget.
2. **Credits** as the single compute currency, with a *published rate card by task class* (Notion's 5, 10, 25 estimates are a start) and a pre-run estimate range.
3. **Outcome pricing** only where success is unambiguous and the agent faces customers (support, scheduling, qualification). Internal knowledge work should not be billed by outcome: success is subjective.
4. **Budget envelopes** on every unattended agent (below), because 24-hour runs break any unit that is only measured after the fact.

Principle: price what the customer values, meter what costs you, and hide neither.

How do you balance quality, speed and inference cost? PROPOSAL Expose three named modes instead of a model list: *Fast* (cheapest adequate model), *Balanced* (Auto, default) and *Best* (capable model, higher credit rate). Keep the router's reasoning inspectable after the fact: show the model used and why it was chosen. Cursor already ships comparable modes on its Teams and Enterprise plans (EXTERNAL SOURCE), so this is a market-tested pattern.

10.2 What happens when an agent runs longer than expected?

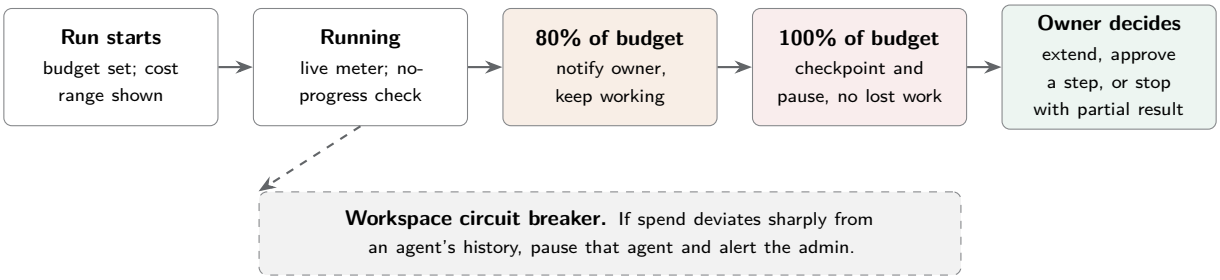


Figure 5. Proposed budget envelope for unattended agents. Not a Notion feature; the 80%/100% thresholds echo Notion's existing alerts.

PROPOSAL

Durable execution (DISCLOSED) is what makes this possible: a queue-backed session can be paused and resumed without losing state, which turns "out of credits" from a failure into a decision. Three rules: (1) the budget is declared *before* the run, not discovered after; (2) a pause always preserves a resumable checkpoint and a partial result; (3) the owner can raise the cap with one action, and the admin can set a ceiling the owner cannot exceed. Notion's own re-route on no-progress (DISCLOSED) should extend to a stop: repeated loops with no progress end the run instead of spending to the cap.

10.3 Product improvements for Notion

PROPOSAL

- **Per-run budgets and pre-run estimates** (above). Per-agent caps already exist; the missing layer is the single run.
- **Cost per outcome.** Let owners tag a run as "succeeded / needed rework / failed" so the dashboard shows credits per successful run, not just credits. Notion already tracks resolution and undo rate when comparing models.
- **Cost-centre tags and showback.** Attribute agent spend to a team or project for internal chargeback.
- **Router transparency.** Show, per run, which models Auto used and why it switched, so spend can be explained.

- **Simplify the two-pool story** by showing one balance with two lanes, and explaining pauses in plain language.

10.4 Potential project: an AI Agent Cost and Usage Management platform

Working name: AgentLedger. **Problem:** each vendor ships its own credits, rates and dashboard, so a company running agents across Notion, Copilot Studio, Agentforce and coding tools cannot see total agent spend, cost per outcome or runaway runs in one place.

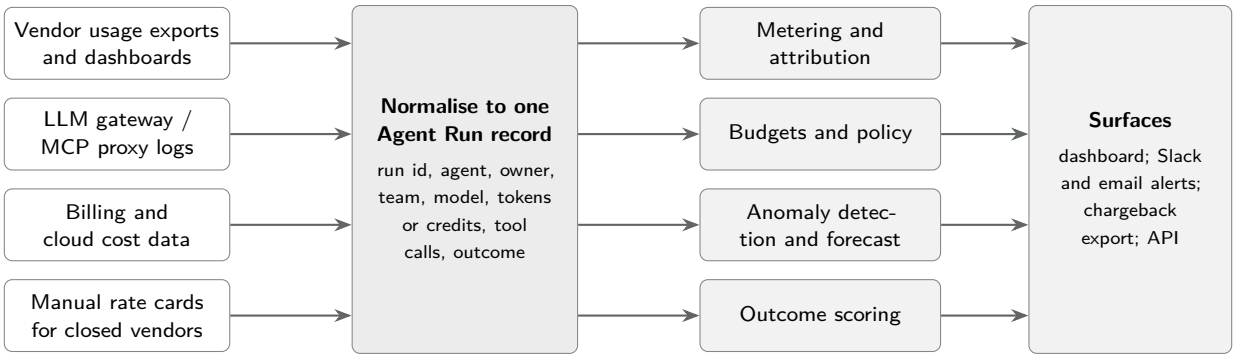


Figure 6. Proposed platform architecture (my design).

PROPOSAL

MVP in about 90 days. Ingest two vendors plus one gateway; normalise to the Agent Run schema; ship a budget and alert engine; add one outcome signal (user-marked success). **Differentiator:** cost per successful outcome across vendors, not another token dashboard. **Main risks:** vendors may not expose per-run cost (UNKNOWN); vendor-native dashboards such as Notion's Command Center will cover the single-vendor case; cloud FinOps incumbents can extend into agents.

11 Metrics

How would you measure success?

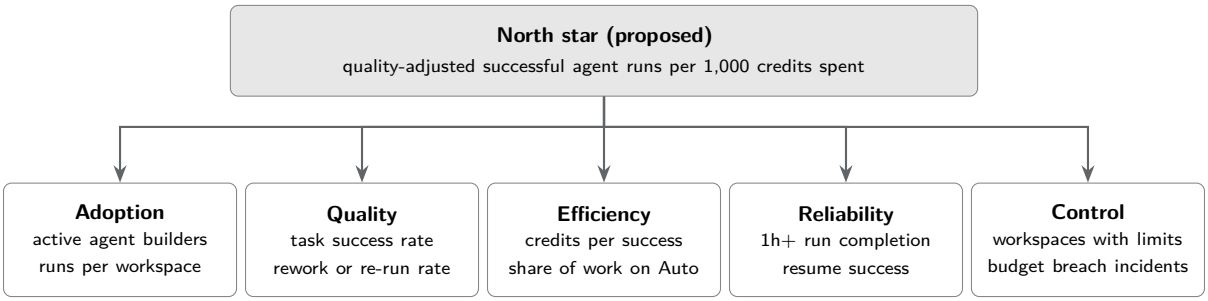


Figure 7. Proposed metric tree. All metrics here are my proposals; none are disclosed by Notion.

Metric	Definition and why it matters	Guardrail or pairing
Credits per successful run	Total credits divided by runs marked successful; the cost of results, not effort	Pair with success rate so cost cannot fall by failing
Router misroute rate	Share of tasks re-routed or re-run after a poor first answer	Watch latency added by re-routing
Share of work on Auto	Proportion of requests left on the router rather than pinned to a model	Segment by task difficulty
Long-run completion	Share of runs over one hour that finish without manual restart	Break out by cause of stop
Pause-then-resume rate	Of runs paused at budget, share resumed and finished by the owner	Low rate suggests stranded work
Pool exhaustion rate	Share of seats or workspaces hitting Standard or Select limits each month	Rising rate may mean allowance too small
Extra-credit purchase rate	Workspaces buying credits beyond the included allowance	Compare against support tickets about cost
Bill-shock tickets	Support contacts about unexpected credit use	Should fall as budgets and estimates ship
Undo rate	Share of agent outputs the user reverts; Notion already tracks this per model in its Knowledge Board (DISCLOSED)	Pair with success rate
Limits adoption	Workspaces with per-member or per-agent limits configured	Indicates admin trust in the controls

NOT DISCLOSED / UNKNOWN

Notion does not publish these metrics for customers, and I will not invent targets. Its Knowledge Board reports resolution rate, cost per task, time and undo rate per model in aggregate, not per workspace. The post and help pages give efficiency claims (about 90% lower cost with Auto; about 30% cheaper Custom Agent runs in testing; apps up to 50% faster; infrastructure uptime above 99.9%) and an estimate that most users will not run out of credits. Business metrics (retention, conversion, CAC, revenue, ARPU, AI gross margin) are unknown. The right first step is to baseline these metrics for two billing cycles, as Notion's own help page recommends for usage, and then set targets.

Experiments I would run. PROPOSAL (1) Show a pre-run cost range to half of Custom Agent builders and compare agent creation and abandonment. (2) Default new agents to a budget envelope versus no budget and compare incidents and completion. (3) Offer Fast, Balanced, Best modes to a random sample and compare credits per success.

12 GTM

Who would buy it, how would you distribute it and monetise it?

12.1 For Notion's credit system

Dimension	Assessment
Buyer	DISCLOSED Business and Enterprise plans carry the included credits. INTERPRETATION Economic buyer: head of IT, operations or finance; champion: team lead building Custom Agents.
Distribution	INTERPRETATION Product-led inside existing workspaces: free-to-try Select credits let a builder prove value before anyone buys extra credits (DISCLOSED). Enterprise adds account-team sales for BYOK and larger credit purchases (DISCLOSED, via the alpha guide reference).
Monetisation	DISCLOSED Seat includes monthly credits; admins buy more at $10 per 1,000 (help page). INTERPRETATION Expansion revenue arrives where heavy agents sit: team-funded Custom Agents and high-cost models.
Unknowns	UNKNOWN Share of revenue from credits, price sensitivity, margin per credit, effect of the credit change on renewals.

12.2 For the AgentLedger project

PROPOSAL

Buyers. FinOps and platform leads who already own cloud cost; IT and security teams asked to govern agent sprawl; CFO offices after the first surprise invoice.
Distribution. (1) A free read-only connector and a "what did your agents cost last month" report as the lead magnet; (2) integrations listed in vendor marketplaces and MCP directories; (3) content aimed at the FinOps community, where agent cost is a fresh topic.
Monetisation. A platform fee tiered by number of managed agents, plus usage-based pricing above a volume threshold. I would avoid a percentage of managed spend: it rewards the vendor when customers spend more, which clashes with a product whose promise is spending less. Offer a savings-share only as an optional enterprise add-on.
Why it could win. Neutrality. A vendor will not show you a cheaper competitor's agent; a cross-vendor layer can.

NOT DISCLOSED / UNKNOWN

Willingness to pay, the size of the cross-vendor segment and the rate at which vendors close the gap with native dashboards are all unvalidated. Before building, interview 10 to 15 admins who run agents on at least two platforms and test whether cross-vendor cost per outcome is a pain they would pay to solve.

Appendix A: Unknowns register (updated)

Question	Status after reading Notion's help pages	How to close it
How was Auto's quality scored?	DISCLOSED Partly answered: replayed tasks, head-to-head judging, Elo, AI judge. UNKNOWN Task mix, human agreement and raw data unpublished	Ask Notion; track the Knowledge Board
Do Custom Agents run on Auto?	DISCLOSED Answered: Auto is the default in Custom Agent settings; the owner can pin a model. Credits come from the owner's Select pool	None needed
What happens to a paused agent's work?	DISCLOSED The agent pauses and resumes on reset or funding. UNKNOWN Mid-run checkpoint behaviour is not documented	Hands-on test with a low cap
Are Select and purchased credits priced alike?	UNKNOWN Only purchased credits are priced ($10 per 1,000); Select value is an assumption in Section 7	Ask Notion; check invoices
Why 87% in the help page and about 90% in the post?	UNKNOWN Possibly rounding or a different cut of the same test	Ask Notion
BYOK alpha terms	UNKNOWN The guide page could not be read (it needs JavaScript or access); BYOK claims rely on the post only	Request the guide from an account team
Share of workspaces exhausting credits; cost of a multi-hour run	UNKNOWN Not published	Customer interviews; hands-on test
Retention, conversion, CAC, revenue, AI gross margin	UNKNOWN Not public	Investor or press disclosures if any
Reviewer-model cost and latency for "Review for me"	UNKNOWN Not published	Hands-on test

Appendix B: Method and limitations

What this teardown is based on. The source post (19 Oct 2026); Notion help pages on Auto, Custom Agent credits, managing credits and buying credits; the Notion Knowledge Board; vendor pricing pages and press releases for competitors. All were read on 9 November 2026.

What it is not based on. No hands-on testing, no customer or admin interviews, no access to Notion usage data, and no reading of the BYOK alpha guide. Every proposal (budget envelope, AgentLedger, metric tree, experiments) is a hypothesis.

How it was made. Drafted with AI assistance (Claude, by Anthropic). Facts were taken from the pages above and labelled by source type; the interpretation and proposals are reasoned, not tested. Pricing and product details change quickly, so re-check before relying on any figure.

Appendix C: Validation plan (not yet done)

Step	What to do	Question it answers
Hands-on test	In a Business workspace, build a small Custom Agent. Run it on Auto, then pinned to a stronger model. Record credits per run, which pool paid, and the dashboard view. Set a very low spending cap and note what the pause looks like and how to resume	Real cost per run; pause behaviour; Auto's savings in practice
Admin interviews	Speak to 10 to 15 admins who run agents on at least two platforms. Ask how they track agent spend today, what a surprise bill looked like, and what they would pay to prevent it	Whether the cross-vendor cost problem is real and paid for
Pricing signal	Show two or three admins a mock rate card with pre-run estimates and per-run caps; ask which they would turn on and why	Whether the budget envelope changes behaviour

Appendix D: Sources

1. Akshay Kothari, *Agents, rebuilt to do more for less*, Notion, 19 Oct 2026. Primary source for post claims.
2. Notion Help, Auto (routing, surfaces, per-task credit estimates, test method).
3. Notion Help, How AI credits work for Custom Agents (credit order, spending caps, pause behaviour).
4. Notion Help, Manage your AI credits (member and admin controls, dashboard).
5. Notion Help, Buy and track Notion credits ($10 per 1,000 credits; 80% and 100% notifications) and Custom Agent pricing.
6. Notion Labs, Knowledge Board (model evaluation method and results; updated 16 Oct 2026).
7. Microsoft Learn, Copilot Studio billing rates and enforcement; CloudZero, Copilot Studio pricing (third party; capacity-pack and pay-as-you-go prices only).
8. Salesforce, Agentforce pricing; Salesforce completes acquisition of Fin, 10 Sep 2026.
9. Fin, Fin AI Agent resolutions (pricing and billing rules).
10. Cursor Docs, Models and pricing.

Not read: the BYOK alpha guide (page not readable without access) and the embedded video. The Notion logo was supplied by the author and is used only to identify the subject; it remains the property of Notion Labs, Inc. Screenshots from the post are not reproduced; all diagrams are my own redrawings.